COLLEGE OF LIBERAL ARTS *IMPACT REPORT*

THE COLLEGE OF CULTURE

JACKSON STATE UNIVERSITY | FALL 2023-SPRING 2026

JSU 1877 JACKSON STATE UNIVERSITY®
COLLEGE OF LIBERAL ARTS

JACKSON STATE UNIVERSITY | FALL 2023-SPRING 2026

THE COLLEGE OF LIBERAL ARTS

featuring

Academic departments

Department of Art
Department of Criminal Justice and Sociology
Department of English and Modern Languages
Department of History and Philosophy
Department of Journalism and Media Studies
Department of Military Science
Department of Music
Department of Political Science
Department of Psychology
Department of Public Policy and Administration
Department of Speech Communication and Theatre

Centers and affiliated special units

Interdisciplinary Alcohol and Drug Studies Center
COFO Civil Rights Education Center
Margaret Walker Center
Richard Wright Center for Writing, Rhetoric, and Research
Africana Digital Humanities Lab
Applied Psychological Services Clinic
Community Health Programs
Bob Owens Pre-Law Center

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MAKING THE WORK POSSIBLE

Institutional support, cultural preservation, centers, grants, and community partnerships.

FROM THE DEAN

Across the College of Liberal Arts, the accomplishments of the past three academic years tell a story of momentum, purpose, and possibility.

Our students are stepping into national opportunities, presenting research, publishing their writing, preparing for law and public service, entering professional media spaces, performing on major stages, exhibiting work in public venues, and using their education to engage the world around them. Their achievements remind us that liberal arts learning does not remain in the classroom. It becomes visible in public speech, creative practice, research, service, leadership, and the courage to imagine a meaningful future.

Our faculty continue to shape the intellectual and creative life of Jackson State University. They publish, perform, create, lead, mentor, win grants and fellowships, build programs, and extend their expertise into communities across Mississippi and beyond. Their work spans the arts, humanities, media, public policy, psychology, history, language, communication, music, theatre, justice, and civic life.

This issue celebrates a College in motion: a College where creativity becomes public presence, scholarship becomes community engagement, and learning becomes preparation for lives of purpose. It also offers a clearer view of the disciplines, programs, centers, and people who carry forward our shared mission.

At Jackson State University, the liberal arts remain essential because they teach us how to interpret the past, understand the present, communicate across difference, imagine new possibilities, and act with responsibility. The accomplishments gathered here are more than individual honors. They are evidence of a living tradition rooted in excellence, service, creativity, and public impact.

Rico D. Chapman

Rico Chapman

MEET THE TEAM

Dean's Office, College of Liberal Arts

Dr. RaShell Smith-Spears,
Associate Dean

Dr. LaTonia Harper,
Executive Assistant

Mrs. Danielle Kirkland,
Administrative Assistant

SCHOOL OF COMMUNICATIONS

The School of Communications unites the College's endeavors in areas such as language, media, writing, storytelling, rhetoric, public voice, literary culture, translation, journalism, and communication research. Students and faculty engage in various environments, including pages, stages, classrooms, studios, public events, online platforms, newsrooms, festivals, and community discussions.

The school's primary inquiry revolves around how language and media navigate through public life. This section offers updates on the latest achievements in English and Modern Languages while highlighting Journalism and Media Studies, showcasing the strong student transition into the industry.

Additionally, it encompasses leadership in writing centers, rhetoric, AI in writing pedagogy, literary partnerships, and the expansion of modern languages, all woven into a cohesive narrative of communications.

JOURNALISM AND MEDIA STUDIES
FROM THE CLASSROOM TO INDUSTRY

In Journalism and Media Studies, students are learning that media work does not end with an assignment. It moves into stadiums, newsrooms, studios, public conversations, professional events, and global classrooms.

Whitley Smith's selection for the 2024 NFL Experienceship Program placed her among only 32 students chosen from more than 100 applicants. The program connected student media training to the sports and entertainment industry, offering a direct view into the pace, professionalism, and storytelling power behind one of the country's most visible media ecosystems.

That kind of opportunity matters because it helps students translate classroom skills into industry confidence. Journalism students learn how to interview, write, shoot, edit, produce, and think critically about audiences. But programs like the NFL Experienceship show them how those skills operate in high-pressure professional environments.

Michael A. White Jr., an award-winning graduate student in Journalism and Media Studies, received a $10,000 BeyGOOD Foundation Scholarship. His recognition connects the department's student work to national philanthropic support and shows how media students are gaining visibility beyond campus.

FOR JOURNALISM AND MEDIA STUDIES STUDENTS, THE CLASSROOM IS ONLY THE BEGINNING OF THE STORY.

Smith was one of 32 students selected to participate in the 2024 NFL Experienceship Program.

Malik Alexander's summer experience carried the department's reach into a different kind of media classroom. As a program counselor at The School of The New York Times Summer Academy, he helped mentor high school students from around the world in one of the most globally diverse journalism learning environments available to young writers and media students. His role positioned him not only as a student, but as a guide for others entering the field.

Malik Alexander mentored students at The School of The New York Times Summer Academy, helping lead an immersive journalism experience for high school students from around the world.

The department also expanded professional access on campus through the inaugural THEE Industry Access Series. The series connected students and the Jackson community with high-profile professionals, including Lionsgate executive Briana McElroy. In conversation with students, McElroy offered a closer look into Hollywood, media production, and the professional pathways that shape entertainment industries.

Together, these experiences show Journalism and Media Studies as a department where students do more than prepare for media careers. They test their voices, build networks, enter professional rooms, and begin to understand how storytelling travels across platforms and industries.

The THEE Industry Access Series brought students into conversation with Lionsgate executive Briana McElroy.

ENGLISH AND MODERN LANGUAGES
SCHOLARSHIPS, HONORS, & STUDENT RECOGNITION

Students within the Department of English and Modern Languages are actively founding organizations, entering graduate programs, presenting at conferences, publishing in national outlets, participating in residencies, and creating a literary community that reaches beyond the classroom.

Graduate students launched the Jackson State Writers Alliance and *Thee 1877 Literary Magazine*, providing a framework for community building, publication opportunities, and peer leadership among student writers. English major Kaitlyn Taylor gained acceptance into the MFA program in creative writing at the University of Maryland. Additionally, English alumnae Kaitlyn Taylor and Victoria Washington had essays published in the special issue of the Callaloo Phillis Wheatley Poetry Festival, with Taylor's piece titled "Me, My Writing, and the South" and Washington's contribution being "Butt of the Joke: Negotiating My Hips."

The 2025-2026 academic year saw an expansion of this student momentum. Several graduate and undergraduate English students presented their work at the 84th College Language Association Convention, including Jayana Wells, Blaise Adams, Amory Campbell, Jailynn Lee, Cameron Griffin, Makayla Hays, Imani Skipwith, and Grace Ann Elinski. Members of Sigma Tau Delta, Grace Ann Elinski and Anndria Norris, also made presentations at the annual conference held in New Orleans.

Creative writing student Ladorian Shelton represents a new generation of JSU writers whose work is being supported through the Patterson Family Foundation scholarship.

Creative writing graduate students presented at the Gwendolyn Brooks conference in Chicago. English graduate students Blaise Adams, Grace Ann Elinski, and Anndria Norris presented at the Mississippi Philological Association conference in Oxford. Undergraduate students also presented at the 2026 CASE Festival under the direction of LaWanda Dickens.

Recent graduates are also moving into professional and graduate pathways: Jordan Robinson was hired as an eighth-grade English teacher and track coach at Burkburnett Middle School in Texas, and Micaela Bowman was accepted into the Master of Arts in Political Science program at the University of Missouri-St. Louis.

WRITING, LITERARY CULTURE, & PUBLIC VOICE

Writing is often perceived as a solitary endeavor: one person, one page, one voice. However, in the School of Communications, writing transforms into a communal practice. It fosters programs, cultivates partnerships, fills auditoriums, supports students, and enriches the literary culture within the city.

A notable illustration of student writing reaching a national literary platform is Grace Ann Elinski's publication in *The Oxford American*, titled "After the Word: The Written-Over Landscapes of Mississippi and South Louisiana." Elinski was also honored with the 2026 Association of Writers and Writing Programs HBCU student fellowship.

Support from faculty leadership has contributed significantly to creating a nurturing environment for student work. Ebony Lumumba was acknowledged as a 2025 Association of Writers and Writing Programs HBCU Faculty Fellow and received the Mississippi Institutions of Higher Learning Excellence in Diversity and Inclusion Award. She has also been awarded the Mississippi Humanities Council Educator of the Year Award. Her expertise in creative writing, Black women's literature, Southern literature, foodways, Afrofuturism, and public humanities illustrates how faculty scholarship can pave the way for aspiring student writers.

The department initiated the JSU Writer-in-Residence program, welcoming Nigerian novelist Sefi Atta. It continued this initiative by hosting award-winning Mississippi poet A.H. Jerriod Avant, whose two-week residency included a craft talk, writing workshops, and literary salons for both students and community members. Additionally, the department facilitated an artist talk featuring Addie Citchens and Jerriod Avant, followed by a visual poetry workshop organized by the Jackson State Writers Alliance.

Lumumba's appointment as a 2025 AWP HBCU Faculty Fellow reflects Jackson State University's continued leadership in supporting and elevating the arts, humanities, and cultural scholarship.

Creative writing has become one of the College's most visible areas for student opportunity. Recently, ten dedicated creative writing students—comprising five undergraduates and five graduates—received $7,500 scholarships from the James Patterson Foundation to bolster their educational journeys and writing aspirations. These scholarships signify more than financial aid; they represent a substantial investment in budding writers whose work traverses fiction, poetry, scriptwriting, public storytelling, literary scholarship, and community arts.

The introduction of the Catherine Coleman Initiative Spring Break Intensive, titled Soul, Sustenance, and Story: A Creative Residency in Literary and Culinary Traditions, offered another crucial platform for student writers. Five creative writing students engaged in a fully funded, week-long series of workshops, salons, and experiential excursions starting in Jackson, Mississippi, and culminating in Harlem, New York. Ebony Lumumba secured $83,206 in JSU RISE grant funding to support this inaugural intensive.

The *In Bloom* mural brought literary concepts to life through visual art. Led by LaWanda Dickens, who acted as the grant writer for the Department of English and Modern Languages, this mural benefited from the Mississippi Arts Commission's support to infuse literary and humanistic works into public spaces.

These achievements showcase writing as a vibrant ecosystem, involving students crafting narratives, faculty developing programs, public events engaging audiences, murals enriching campus spaces, and partnerships connecting JSU to the city's rich cultural life.

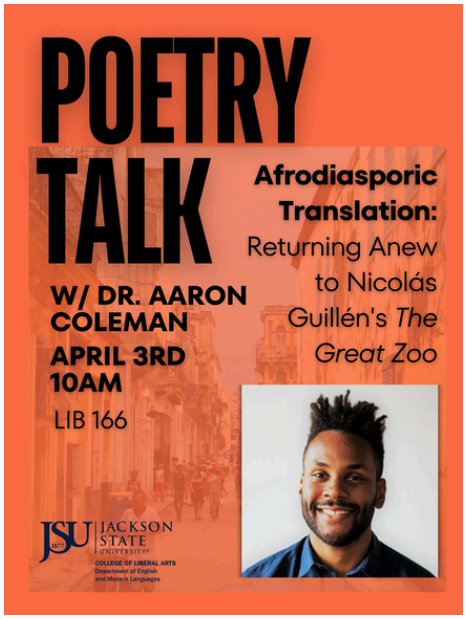
Tabitha Brown shares her story at the Jackson Convention Complex in Jackson, Mississippi.

LaWanda Dickens spearheaded the mural project as the grant writer on behalf of Jackson State University's Department of English and Modern Languages.

MODERN LANGUAGES & GLOBAL COMMUNICATION

The Department of English and Modern Languages is also expanding the College's global communication infrastructure. The department reintroduced Mandarin language and culture courses and introduced Arabic language and culture courses through the Fulbright Language Teaching Assistant program, bringing Fulbright language instructors from Taiwan and Kuwait to campus. It maintained Mandarin offerings in the following year and, in 2025-2026, inaugurated Swahili language and culture courses through a Fulbright from Kenya.

The Department of English and Modern Languages welcomed Dr. Kelly Norman Ellis, visiting associate professor of English and creative writing, and Sefi Atta, distinguished writer-in-residence for the 2024-2025 academic year.



Modern Languages faculty also facilitated an International Poetry and Culture Event, while Spanish minor Zaria Miller introduced Dr. Aaron Coleman before his craft talk on Pablo Neruda's poetry and Spanish translation.

Na Li's certification for Teachers of Chinese to Speakers of Other Languages strengthens this infrastructure, adding faculty expertise to the department's language offerings. In a College that emphasizes public voice, language study matters not only as a curricular offering but also as a pathway into translation, intercultural communication, diaspora studies, global literature, and international engagement.

Authors Angie Thomas (shown above), Paula J. Giddings, and Nic Stone discussed the state of Black literature at the Banned Books luncheon and conversation during the 2023 Phillis Wheatley Poetry Festival.

COLLEGE LANGUAGE ASSOCIATION & PUBLIC HUMANITIES INFRASTRUCTURE

The Department of English and Modern Languages has significantly enhanced the College's academic prestige by hosting the 84th College Language Association Convention. This prestigious event drew over 250 participants, establishing Jackson State as a central gathering place for scholars, writers, students, and educators committed to exploring language, literature, culture, and Black intellectual traditions.

Ebony Lumumba chaired the 50th Anniversary Reconvening of the Phillis Wheatley Poetry Festival, while the department and College partners played a crucial role in preserving the festival's legacy as one of Jackson State's most esteemed public humanities traditions.

Building on the success of the Phillis Wheatley Poetry Festival, the department collaborated with Academic Affairs and the General Education program to develop Thee Blueprint. This innovative Canvas-based curriculum guide helps faculty across campus integrate festival themes into their courses.

From left: Nikole Hannah-Jones, Dana Williams and Eve L. Ewing discuss Phillis Wheatley during the Phillis Wheatley Poetry Festival 50th Anniversary on Nov. 2, 2023.

Author Jesmyn Ward explains the circumstances that inspired her recent novel "Let Us Descend" at the "Our People" panel at the Phillis Wheatley Poetry Festival 50th anniversary.

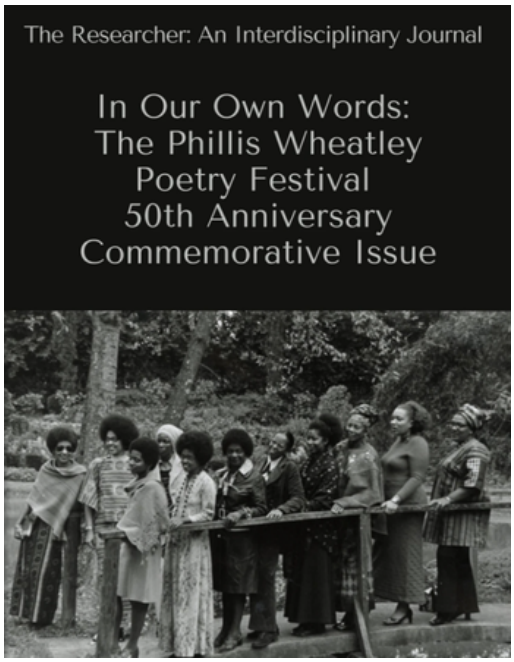
FACULTY RESEARCH & PUBLIC VOICE

In the School of Communications, faculty research explores how language, media, rhetoric, literature, writing, translation, storytelling, and public communication influence civic and cultural life. The School's scholarship spans creative writing, literary studies, writing center research, modern languages, journalism, media studies, health communication, public rhetoric, and digital culture.

In English and Modern Languages, faculty scholarship has substantially expanded in literary studies, creative writing, rhetoric, modern languages, and writing studies. Ebony Lumumba's work bolsters JSU's presence in African American literary scholarship and creative writing. Her publications focus on Black women's writing, Eudora Welty, Toni Morrison, Africana mothering, transnational Black women writers, foodways, resistance, liberation, and literary inheritance. Her recent and upcoming scholarship includes work in *Women's Studies, Callaloo*, *College Language Association Journal*, and others. Her ACLS HBCU Finalist Grant, "Storying the Stomach: Black Mothering Food Stories as Archive and Revolutions of Care," further extends research into food, memory, Black maternal practice, and care.

Wonderful Faison's work through the Richard Wright Center showcases the national significance of writing center studies and HBCU writing program administration. Her 2024 International Writing Centers Association Outstanding Book Award established her as a leader in equitable writing pedagogy. Her 2026 publications, including an edited collection on writing center and writing program administration at HBCUs, position JSU within national conversations about writing instruction and academic support.

Craig A. Meyer's published scholarship links rhetoric, writing studies, disability, artificial intelligence, popular culture, law, and pedagogy. His work covers topics like generative AI, constructed languages, dysfluency, disability and science fiction, toxic rhetoric, and classical rhetoric in contemporary law.



Modern Languages faculty also extend the School's international and comparative reach. Leticia Pérez Alonso's research on Hollywood, the Cuban avant-garde, Leonora Carrington, Remedios Varo, and Spanish Civil War poetics places visual culture, cinema, literature, and modernity in transnational conversation. Brian Phillips' work in Cervantes studies, truth, early modern Spanish literature, and cultural nonnormativity has been supported by ACLS and JSU research funding, while his collaboration with Leticia Pérez Alonso on Spanish Film Club programming connects scholarship to public cultural engagement.

The School's creative and public humanities profile is equally strong. Shanna Smith's work includes publications and presentations on Phillis Wheatley, Black girlhood, Black Appalachia, food, justice, young adult art, and activism. RaShell Smith-Spears' publications in creative and scholarly venues address Black womanhood, Black family representation, horror, home, love, and popular culture. LaWanda Dickens' public humanities work includes presentations on Mississippi women, literacy, activism, and community-based literary programming.

Journalism and Media Studies faculty add another essential dimension to the School's research profile. Jewell Davis' Water, *Power and Politics: A Quantitative Content Analysis of Local and National Media Coverage of the Jackson Water Crisis* analyzes how media institutions represent public crisis, infrastructure, and power. Nathan A. Towery's research on loyalty, sport, political and religious identification, and transgression diminishment connects media and communication studies to questions of identity, affiliation, and public perception.

SCHOOL OF FINE & PERFORMING ARTS

The School of Fine and Performing Arts encompasses the College's most prominent forms of creative expression, including sound, movement, performance, visual communication, studio work, exhibitions, design, theatre, and music education. Its activities span various venues such as concert halls, football fields, galleries, opera workshops, classrooms, community sites, festivals, and national stages. This is a place where students learn to create, perform, interpret, and showcase culture publicly.

The narratives in this section highlight creative work as both an educational journey and a public service. Students are not just preparing for careers in the arts; they are actively engaging in design for local businesses, performing for national audiences, competing in regional and national music events, exhibiting their creations, and representing Jackson State in environments where HBCU creativity holds significant institutional and cultural influence.

MUSIC & PERFORMANCE PATHWAYS

Music students are creating diverse pathways across various disciplines, including voice, opera, musical theatre, classical performance, jazz, wind and string ensembles, percussion, gospel, African drum and dance, and HBCU marching traditions. Their achievements reflect a department where performance transcends a single genre or stage, showcasing talent in regional competitions, national auditions, public ceremonies, university events, international festivals, and professional opera pipelines.

Kaytie Jeffries, Ryan Fields, and Julia Johnson proudly represented Jackson State at the Southern Region National Association of Teachers of Singing. Jeffries secured first place in the Upper Division American Spiritual category and second place in the Upper Division Commercial Music category. Fields earned second place in the Lower Division Commercial Music category. Johnson also achieved second place in the Lower Division American Spiritual category. All three students qualified for the National NATS Student Auditions, which further enhances the department's vocal presence beyond the campus.

In addition, Kaytie Jeffries participated in the Denyce Graves Foundation's Shared Voices program, a national initiative aimed at supporting emerging vocal artists. Her selection is a direct result of the Department of Music's collaboration with the Denyce Graves Foundation, which has invited Jackson State to be one of seven HBCUs involved in the Shared Voices program. Through this partnership, students gain insights into the professional expectations of vocal performance, while faculty mentorship plays a crucial role in sustaining their career pathways.

Kaytie Jeffries represented Jackson State through the Denyce Graves Foundation's Shared Voices program, with Phyllis Lewis-Hale selected as a faculty mentor.

Christopher Dixon, Lamont Bell, and Shelbie Newman became the first HBCU students to intern in the Harmony Project Precision Drill Marching Band Camp.

Josiah Osula earned both the Black Violin Foundation James Miles Musical Innovation Grant Award and a statewide MTNA competition win.

Instrumental students are receiving well-deserved recognition, particularly Josiah Osula, who made history as the first HBCU student to win the Strings Division of the Senior Music Teachers National Association competition in Mississippi. This achievement underscores the effectiveness of one-on-one mentorship and boosts the department's reputation in classical performance.

The department also takes pride in celebrating several other accomplishments. Ginaia Black has been named the Portland Opera's Resident Artist for 2024-2025, while Savion Lucious has been selected as Opera Mississippi's Young Artist. The JSU Choir has reached the finals for the Texas Gospel Music Excellence Award. The JSU Wind Ensemble, under the direction of Dr. Roderick Little, performed at the Minority Band Invitational in Georgia. The trombone choir received positive feedback at the USM Brass Symposium, led by Mr. Orel Lee. Additionally, Tyfarri Lee was honored with the Presser Award for his advocacy in music equity.

Together, these achievements show the Department of Music as a place where student musicians move from campus preparation into competitive, professional, and public-facing spaces. The department's ensembles perform at university ceremonies, civic events, scholarship luncheons, festivals, conferences, and community gatherings, making music one of the College's most visible forms of public engagement.

The JSU Chorale inspired Westlake High School students through its artistry, mentorship, and participation in the school's inaugural HBCU Choir Tour.

CREATIVITY ON THE GLOBAL STAGE

SONIC BOOM

THE SONIC BOOM CARRIES JACKSON STATE'S IDENTITY INTO NATIONAL ARENAS WHILE GROUNDING THAT VISIBILITY IN MUSICAL DISCIPLINE, PRECISION, AND TRADITION.

The Sonic Boom of the South remains one of Jackson State University's most recognizable cultural signatures. Every performance carries musical precision, visual discipline, institutional pride, HBCU tradition, and the energy of students who understand that they are representing something larger than themselves. When Sonic Boom enters a stadium, televised stage, parade route, or festival environment, it carries Jackson State with it.

Recent milestones have placed the program in some of the most visible performance settings in the country. Sonic Boom performed for Super Bowl LVIII with Usher, performed at the Parade of Roses in California, received resolutions from the City Council and the City of Jackson, and participated in the National Folk Festival. The band has also appeared in major entertainment spaces, including previous national stages with artists and platforms that amplified the reach of HBCU marching traditions.

These appearances are major performance credits, but they are also cultural events. They show the continuing relevance of HBCU marching band traditions and the distinctive role Jackson State plays in that tradition. Sonic Boom's performances are rooted in repetition, discipline, rehearsal, and musical preparation, but they also produce emotion, recognition, and collective memory.

CREATIVITY & CULTURE
FROM ARCHIVE TO STAGE

The Department of Music's opera initiatives exemplify how archives, performance, partnerships, and student opportunities can harmoniously converge within the College. *Jubilee*, a folk opera inspired by Margaret Walker Alexander's legacy, unites various entities: the Margaret Walker Center, the Department of Music, collaborators from Yale, Opera South, faculty leaders, student performers, and national arts funding. This project transforms archival memories into expressive voice, movement, libretto, and stage practice.

In a remarkable debut of *Jubilee*, JSU Opera and Musical Theater shared the stage with Yale students on the Yale campus. This performance crafted a significant institutional narrative: a project rooted in Jackson State and Margaret Walker's literary heritage extending into a national university setting through artistic expression. It underscored the potential of HBCU opera and musical theater as platforms for collaboration, training, and historical interpretation.

The HBCU Opera and Musical Theater Summer Festival, along with the Opera/South Revitalization Initiative, provide a broader framework for this work. Dr. Phyllis Lewis-Hale was awarded a $20,000 grant from the National Endowment for the Arts to support the festival. Additionally, alongside Dr. Robert Luckett, she secured a $125,000 Yale ASCEND grant for the HBCU Opera and Musical Theater Summer Festival. Previous NEA support has also played a crucial role in establishing the HBCU Summer Opera South program. These investments highlight that the College's creative endeavors extend beyond mere performance events; they serve as a vital institutional platform.

The Margaret Walker Center (MWC) and Department of Music at Jackson State University (JSU) will host the inaugural HBCU Opera and Musical Theater Summer Festival in June. Shown are three of JSU's scholars chosen to be a part of the festival: (L-R) Donte Wright, Julia Johnson, and Joshua Taylor.

The project also expands the relationship between creative writing and opera. English and Modern Languages collaborated with Opera South to host the "Sounding Black: Voice, Libretto, and the Future of Opera" craft session and the "What If Your Story Sang? Considering Opera as Craft" masterclass for creative writing students, led by Jarrod Lee. This cross-school connection shows how libretto, voice, literary craft, archival memory, and performance can become part of a shared curriculum.

THEATRE, SPEECH ARTS, & STUDENT LEADERSHIP

Performance is often characterized by what unfolds on stage. At the college level, theatre and speech arts also serve as vital avenues for leadership, discipline, collaboration, and public expression. During the 86th Annual National Association of Dramatic and Speech Arts Conference, JSU proudly returned with over five prestigious awards and two national officer positions. Thirty students showcased their talents at the national conference, marking a significant milestone for the department and increasing the number of students who can access a professional network in performance and speech arts.

Christian Johnson and the JSU performing arts students received top honors at the conference, with Johnson being elected as the national student body president. This accomplishment broadens the department's student leadership role beyond the campus and into a national organization. Theatre students Kamiylah Peoples and Jasmine Sloan expressed their gratitude for Yolanda Williams' mentorship, highlighting its role in fostering encouragement and resilience. Their experiences remind us that student success relies not only on opportunities but also on supportive faculty who guide students on their journey.

Thirty students represented JSU at the 86th Annual National Association of Dramatic and Speech Arts Conference.

MADDRAMA's performances and conference recognition show how JSU theatre students are building artistic and professional presence beyond campus.

MADDRAMA's journey with advisor Mark Henderson to New York resulted in the performance of *Mississippi to Manhattan*: New Dance Works by JSU alumnus Jaylen Taylor. This experience created a profound geographic and artistic connection, showcasing work rooted in Mississippi as it transitions into one of the nation's major cultural hubs, all presented by JSU performers and influenced by an alumnus whose creative endeavors continue to resonate with the university.

The strength of faculty leadership further enhances this ecosystem. Yolanda Williams has contributed significantly by serving on the Board of Directors for the United States Institute for Theatre Technology, chairing its Black, Indigenous, and People of Color Network, and being a member of the Southeastern Theatre Conference board. Her professional involvement places JSU's theatre initiatives within larger discussions surrounding representation, technical theatre, regional performance, and national arts leadership.

Student Isaac Grimes performing.

Christian Johnson's performance and leadership reflect the Department of Theatre's growing national presence.

IN THEATRE, STUDENTS LEARN TO CARRY VOICE, PRESENCE, & LEADERSHIP INTO THE WORLD.

VISUAL ARTS
CREATIVE PRACTICE BEYOND THE ASSIGNMENT

Some student projects begin as simple class assignments, but the most impactful work extends far beyond the classroom. At the College of Liberal Arts, students are transforming their assignments into public-facing initiatives that reach restaurants, galleries, stages, conferences, and community venues, where effective communication becomes essential.

In the field of Art, students Ashanti Stiff, Michael Brown, and Tyler Tremble collaborated with Visit JXN and local eateries to develop logos, signage, and branding materials as part of a hands-on rebranding effort. Under the guidance of Mark Geil, chair of JSU's Department of Art, these students aided local businesses in rethinking their visual identities. Stiff's logo and redesign for Sugar's Place integrated student design into the heart of downtown Jackson.

Such projects challenge students to tackle problems that are both innovative and practical. A logo must not only be visually appealing but also encapsulate a business's identity. Signage should be eye-catching while functioning effectively in public spaces. Branding has to be unique, yet it must communicate clearly with customers and community members. Through this collaboration, students discovered that design transcends style; it encompasses communication, location, and trust.

WHEN STUDENT WORK ENTERS PUBLIC SPACE, THE ASSIGNMENT BECOMES A PROFESSIONAL BEGINNING.

Mark Geil, chair of JSU's Department of Art, stands with graphic design students Ashanti Stiff, Michael Brown, and Tyler Tremble in front of Sugar's Place in downtown Jackson.

Visual art in the College also lives through student ambition. Tyler "Fooly" Goliday, a senior studio art major with an emphasis in painting, debuted his first solo exhibition, *The Origin of the Pessimist*, at the Municipal Art Gallery in Jackson.

The exhibition explored identity, transformation, doubt, anxiety, depression, and resilience through portraits, acrylic painting, digital media, and photography. Works such as *Life's a Game* used chess imagery to reflect strategy, choice, and the difficulty of moving forward, while other pieces honored Black women, family memory, HBCU bands, Black cowboys, and the complexity of the Black experience. Goliday's debut shows how JSU student artists are not simply preparing for the art world; they are already entering it with mature visual languages.

Tyler Goliday held his solo exhibition The Origin of the Pessimist at the Municipal Art Gallery.

Visual art in the College of Liberal Arts spans a diverse range of activities, seamlessly moving between studio practice, public design, exhibition, scholarship, and the preservation of cultural memory. It manifests in various forms, such as captivating galleries and vibrant murals, and is integral to student branding projects, faculty research, and the physical spaces that bring creative work to life.

During Homecoming 2024, a noteworthy collaboration with Getty Images led to a remarkable exhibition at the Johnson Hall Art Gallery, showcasing over a century of Jackson State history. This exhibition transformed visual archives into a public encounter with institutional memory, offering visitors a unique opportunity to witness JSU history through a rich tapestry of images. These images provided an engaging glimpse into the university's past and present.

The department's faculty exhibition *Material and Memory* was mounted at the Municipal Art Gallery in 2023 and featured current and former JSU art faculty, including Mark Geil, Charles Carraway, Kenyatta Stewart, Hosik Kim, Hyun Kim, Chalmers Mayers, and Brittany Myburgh. The exhibition's title captured a central concern of the department's work: how materials carry memory, and how artistic practice gives form to experience, history, and interpretation.

Faculty creative and scholarly work extends the department's presence beyond campus. Hosik Kim held his solo exhibition *Engrave* at Belhaven University. Brittany Myburgh's review of the Mississippi Art Invitational "Call Home" in *Panorama: Journal of the Association of Historians of American Art* connects visual art to criticism.

Collaboration with Getty Images to showcase over 100 years of Jackson State University History.

Hosik Kim's art installation for Material and Memory at the Jackson Municipal Art Gallery.

TEACHING, MENTORSHIP, & CREATIVE FUTURES

Teaching honors across the College affirm the central role of instruction, mentorship, and humanities education in the public mission of Fine and Performing Arts. Together, the Humanities Teacher of the Year honors show an unusually strong record of recognition for fine and performing arts faculty across the College.

Faculty excellence extends beyond teaching awards. Dr. Lisa Beckley-Roberts received support from the Mississippi Department of Health to study the impact of Africana music, dance, and arts on health disparities in the African American community in the Jackson metro area; received Mississippi Humanities Council support to host blues legend Super Chikan; led national conversations about diversity, equity, and inclusion in music units; served in accreditation and professional leadership roles; was elected to the College Music Society Board as Ethnomusicology Representative; and received the 2026 Distinguished Black Classical Excellence Award as a Luminary in Ethnomusicology.

Dr. Phyllis Lewis-Hale published two volumes of spirituals arranged by Afro-Caribbean composer Andres Wheatley, judged regional and international vocal competitions, presented on Louisiana Afro-Creole folk songs, served on the Education Advisory Committee of the Denyce Graves Foundation, and received the 2026 Luminary in Arts Equity and Education in Vocal Performance from the Distinguished Black Classical Excellence Awards.

2023 Humanities Teacher of the Year

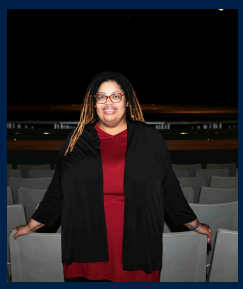
Brittany Myburgh, Assistant Professor of Art History, Department of Art

2024 Humanities Teacher of the Year

LaTannia Ellerbe, Assistant Professor of Strings, Department of Music

2025 Humanities Teacher of the Year

Ramon Jackson, Assistant Professor of Music Education, Department of Music



2026 Humanities Teacher of the Year

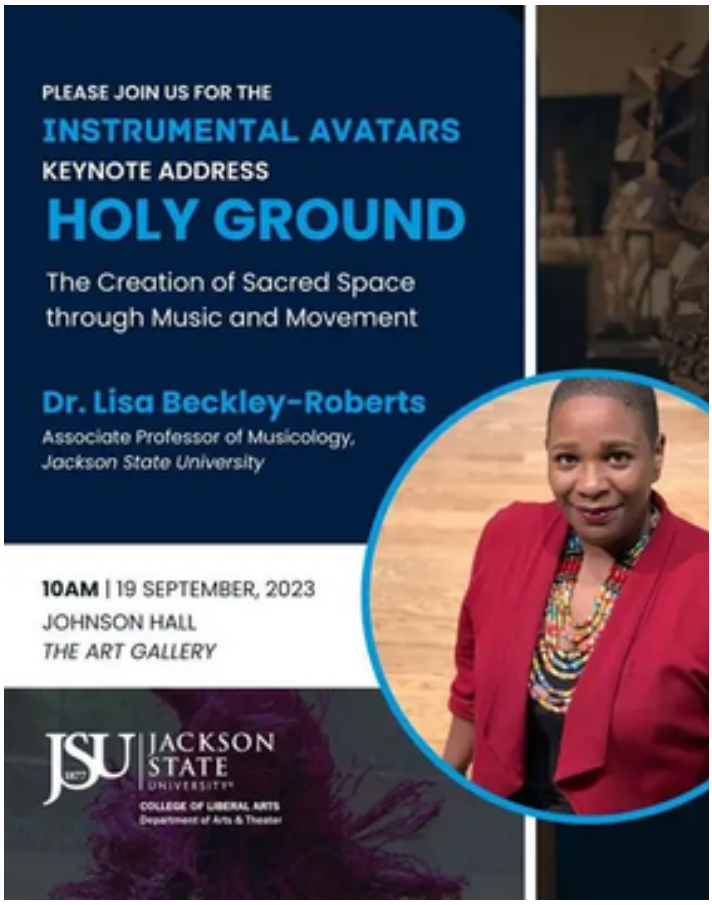
Yolanda Williams, Assistant professor and Theatre Coordinator, Department of Speech Communication & Theatre

Dr. David Mahloch published *Aural Skills Training: A Practical Approach to Sight Singing and Dictation* and had his composition "Pastorale" for oboe and piano performed at the College Music Society Southern Chapter Meeting. Dr. Roderick Little was selected as HBCU Curriculum Lead for Silent Command Music Educational Consultant Service and hosted the inaugural HBCU Student and Director Music Conference.

These achievements matter because they show the School of Fine and Performing Arts building an ecosystem: students perform and exhibit, faculty publish and lead, programs host festivals and institutes, and creative work becomes both a public face and a future pathway for the College.

FACULTY RESEARCH & CREATIVE SCHOLARSHIP

In the School of Fine and Performing Arts, research is often inseparable from creative practice. Faculty scholarship moves through galleries, studios, rehearsal rooms, concert halls, archives, classrooms, and public performance spaces. It asks how sound, movement, image, material, performance, and memory shape human experience.

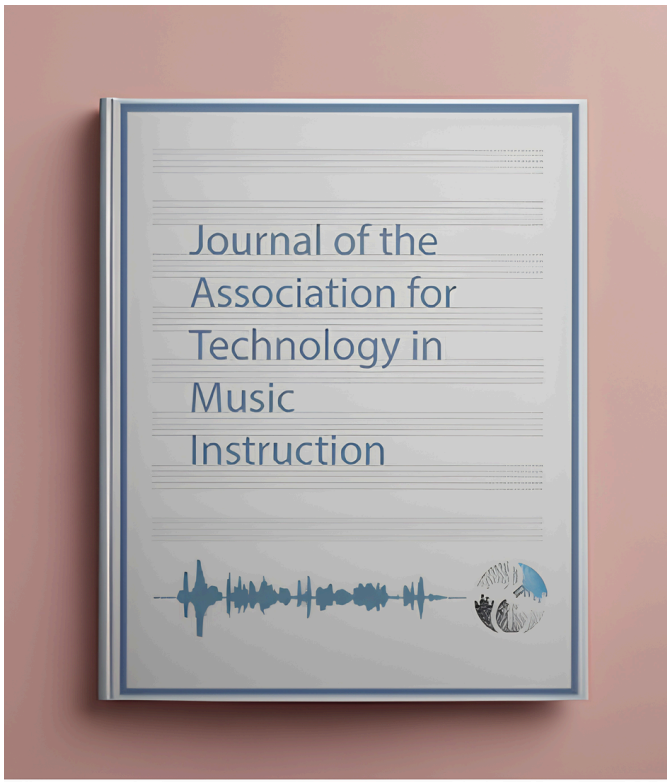


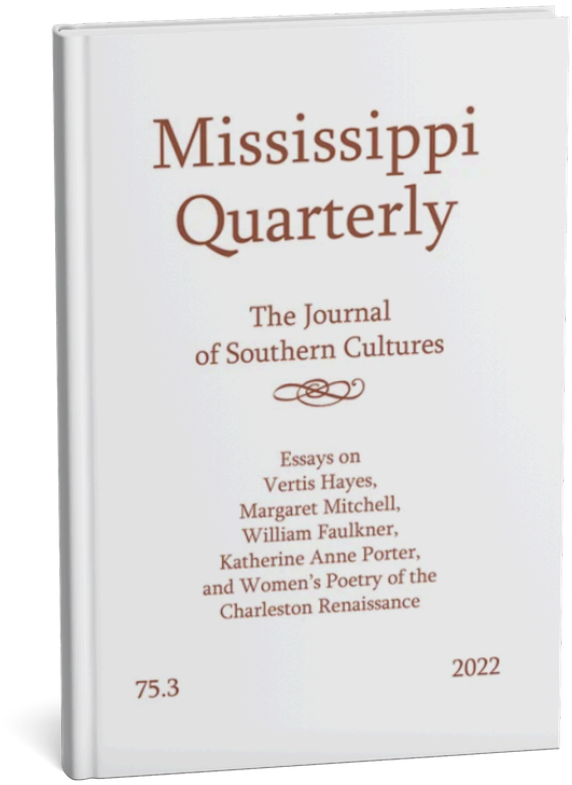
In Music, faculty research demonstrates the School's strength across ethnomusicology, music education, vocal performance, composition, music technology, and culturally grounded performance practice.

Lisa Beckley-Roberts is a prominent researcher in Africana music and dance, focusing on health disparities and HBCU music programs. Her notable work includes a grant from the Mississippi Department of Health on Africana arts' impact on health, collaborations with blues artist Super Chikan, and leadership in ethnomusicology.

Ramon Jackson enhances music education as a cultural practice, with recent publications on teaching the Civil Rights Movement through Orff-Schulwerk and using children's play songs for urban learners. He has presented at national conferences and will serve as a clinician for the 2026 International Summer Course at the Orff Institute, merging history, movement, and culturally responsive pedagogy in music education.

Phyllis Lewis-Hale enhances vocal performance and Black classical traditions through her scholarship and leadership, publishing volumes of spirituals and receiving national recognition as a 2026 Luminary in Arts Equity and Education. She supports the HBCU Opera & Musical Theater Summer Festival, linking faculty scholarship to student opportunities.





Other faculty achievements include LaTannia Ellerbe's recital and American premiere performance, David Mahloch's publication and performance of his composition, and Roderick Little's role as HBCU Curriculum Lead, contributing to music education and band leadership.

Ivan Elezovic's multimedia project "Drawing Noise," was featured in the *Journal of the Association for Technology in Music Instruction* and performed at the 2025 ATMI National Conference in Spokane, Washington. Created with art director Chung-Fan Chang and director of photography and video Mark Geil, *Drawing Noise* brings together audio engineering, video production, performance art, and works on paper to investigate the relationship among sound, noise, music, gesture, and mark-making. As with many examples in this section, the work is an example of inter-department collaboration in the School of Fine and Performing Arts.

In Art, faculty scholarship examines the relationship between visual culture, public memory, African American art history, and institutional legacy. Brittany Myburgh's art historical work explores visual culture, light, modernism, public art, and African American mural history. Her peer-reviewed scholarship includes work on Thomas Wilfred, Lumia, and the medium of light, as well as research on Vertis Hayes and the Johnson Hall Carver mural. This scholarship connects the department's studio and art history work to broader conversations about abstraction, public art, Black visual culture, and the preservation of campus-based artistic memory.

SCHOOL OF SOCIAL & BEHAVIORAL SCIENCES

The School of Social and Behavioral Sciences encompasses the College's initiatives in various fields, including civic life, public policy, justice, social behavior, psychology, history, philosophy, public administration, law preparation, health equity, archives, and cultural memory.

Its departments and centers are designed to help students understand the functioning of institutions, explore how communities preserve their memories, analyze how policy influences daily life, and transform research into public service. This section includes Political Science, Criminal Justice and Sociology, Psychology, Public Policy and Administration, History and Philosophy, the Bob Owens Pre-Law Center, the Margaret Walker Center, the COFO Civil Rights Education Center, and the Interdisciplinary Alcohol and Drug Studies Center. Additionally, it is home to the College's most comprehensive efforts in archives, memory, public humanities, and community-engaged research.

CRIMINAL JUSTICE & SOCIOLOGY

CULTIVATING COMMUNITY RESPONSIBILITY

Daeja Sawyer, a sophomore majoring in criminal justice, was inducted into the National Society of Collegiate Scholars. Her recognition reflects the academic determination of students preparing to address questions of justice, community, public safety, and institutional responsibility.

Student achievement in criminal justice and sociology also extends into community-based research. In 2025, JSU students Yahkeemya Yisrael and Shayla Wright worked alongside students from Millsaps College on Jackson Court Watch, a project of the national organization Neighborhood Defender Service. Through the project, the students helped collect data on local court proceedings that informed policy recommendations concerning disparities in courtroom practices. Their participation demonstrates how undergraduate research can contribute to public understanding, institutional accountability, and the pursuit of more equitable systems of justice.

These accomplishments are supported by a network of faculty mentors, community partners, alumni, donors, and institutions committed to creating opportunities for students. Jennifer Love, a distinguished Jackson State alumna and retired FBI agent, strengthened that network by establishing a $100,000 endowed scholarship in criminal justice. Her gift provides long-term support for students preparing for careers in law, justice, public safety, and public service.

The presence of retired and active FBI personnel at Jackson State in support of Love's gift reflects its intergenerational significance: alumni and professionals returning to invest in the students who will carry this work forward.

Daeja Sawyer: "This shows my determination, and it means a lot to me. It's also reassuring to be recognized for the good things that I'm doing," Sawyer shared. "This motivates me to keep going."

Retired and active members of the FBI visit JSU to support Jennifer Love, a JSU alumna and retired FBI agent, who established a $100,000 endowed scholarship at her alma mater.

STUDENTS ARE ALREADY SHAPING THE INTELLECTUAL, CIVIC, AND CULTURAL LIFE AROUND THEM.

Khalilah Karriem, president of JSU's student chapter of the NAACP, speaks at the Mississippi NAACP Advocacy Day rally at the state Capitol.

Kennedy Pierce was named a 2023–2025 Obama-Chesky Voyager Scholar for Public Service

Camrynn Wimberly (top) and Jakari Holland (below) participated in the Public Policy & International Affairs (PPIA) Fellowship Program

POLITICAL SCIENCE

PREPARING PUBLIC LEADERS

Political Science students have recently gained significant national recognition. Kennedy Pierce has been awarded the title of 2023–2025 Obama-Chesky Voyager Scholar for Public Service, a prestigious honor that acknowledges students dedicated to civic leadership and making a public impact. Meanwhile, Khalilah Karriem has been included in the 2025 ALL IN Student Voting Honor Roll, a testament to her leadership in promoting democratic participation, voter education, and civic engagement.

Karriem's leadership extends beyond the campus. As the president of JSU's student chapter of the NAACP, she delivered a compelling speech at the Mississippi NAACP Advocacy Day rally at the state Capitol, advocating for Medicaid expansion and educational equity. Her powerful presence at the microphone embodies the essence of this section of the magazine: students leveraging their liberal arts education not only to analyze public life but also to actively engage in it.

These achievements reflect a student body gaining momentum through scholarship, service, leadership, and creative ambition. While the awards are significant, the narratives behind them reveal something much deeper.

Camrynn Wimberly illustrates this journey by elevating her undergraduate research to a national platform. After participating in the Ralph Bunche Summer Institute at Duke University, she presented her work at the American Political Science Association Conference in Vancouver. Her experience underscores the importance of early research opportunities, particularly for students preparing for graduate studies, public policy, or academic careers.

Wimberly's words convey a clear sense of purpose: "Upon graduation, I plan to continue conducting research, publishing valuable, scientifically grounded information, and potentially becoming a professor to mentor young adults." This statement transforms her accomplishments into a visionary outlook. For her, research transcends mere credentials; it serves as a pathway to contribute knowledge and ultimately guide others.

PUBLIC LEADERSHIP BEGINS WHEN STUDENTS SEE RESEARCH, LAW, AND CIVIC LIFE AS PLACES WHERE THEIR VOICES BELONG.

The department's Bob Owens Pre-Law Center, under the direction of Dr. Charles Irvin, is also growing. The Center has expanded its network of law-school, judicial, and professional partners through campus visits, mentoring events, LSAT preparation, legal-rights forums, pathway programs, and opportunities for direct engagement with attorneys and judges.

Recent programming has connected students with representatives from the University of Mississippi School of Law, Mississippi College School of Law, Harvard Law School, Yale Law School, Drake University Law School, and Samford University's Cumberland School of Law. Students have also participated in the Law School Admission Council Forum, the BAR Pre-Law Tour, the Dean Louis Westerfield Judicial Symposium, the Forman Watkins Spring Pathway Program, and lectures examining law, civil rights, and public service.

The Center's institutional foundation was further strengthened by a $300,000 AccessLex grant supporting the Bob Owens Pre-Law Center Pipeline Program from 2025 through 2027. This investment expands the Center's capacity to prepare students for law-school admission, professional expectations, and careers in legal advocacy.

Pre-law experiences give students early exposure to the professional networks and legal pathways that can shape their futures.

That work builds upon student participation in programs such as the Future Black Lawyer Institute. Kennadie Boykin, Jadyn Cunningham, Kourtney Graves, Mckenzie Greer, and Jordyn Jackson attended the Institute's workshop in Phoenix during Super Bowl LVII weekend. The experience placed them in a professional-development environment designed to expand access to legal education and help students envision themselves as future attorneys, advocates, and public leaders.

SCHOLARS IN THE FIELD

JUSTICE, POLICY & PUBLIC SERVICE

In the College of Liberal Arts, faculty engage in research that crosses traditional academic boundaries, addressing key questions on community memory, institutional crisis management, and the impacts of race, health, and media on human experiences. Their work spans scholarly publications, public humanities projects, and writing center research across arts, humanities, and social sciences, underscoring the College's commitment to understanding cultural dynamics and promoting equity in education.

Rico Chapman's Fulbright U.S. Scholar award for research in South Africa enhanced his academic profile and expanded the College's global influence by intertwining individual scholarship with broader cultural dialogues. Similarly, Kofi Barima's Fulbright award advanced his study of Afro-Jamaican spiritual history at the University of the West Indies, strengthening Jackson State's Caribbean academic ties and exemplifying the College's dedication to connecting diverse regions and histories within the African diaspora. Faculty like Byron D'Andra Orey, elected president of the Southern Political Science Association, showcase the College's leadership in political science.

The College's influence is also evident through substantial research grants, such as the $509,000 NSF grant for a study on racial trauma. Faculty like Gloria Billingsley, appointed chairperson of NASPAA's Commission on Peer Review and Accreditation, play a crucial role in shaping public affairs education standards. In 2026, Billingsley was selected as a Fellow in the National Academy of Public Administration. Through these efforts, faculty are not just generating knowledge but also building programs, leading initiatives, and preparing students to contribute significantly to the global intellectual landscape.

Rico D. Chapman

Byron D'Andra Orey

Gloria Billingsley

Dawn Bishop McLin, Ph.D., principal investigator, and project director of the $1.5 million grant for health-equity research.

Three of Jackson State University's Interdisciplinary Alcohol and Drug Studies Center staff accept the Public Service Award for Alcohol Prevention and Safe Driving at the 2024 Lifesavers Conference. Shown from L-R are Keith McMillian, occupant safety coordinator, Michelle Young, driving education prevention specialist, and Nita Hilton, director of the IADSC.

PSYCHOLOGY & HEALTH

HEALTH EQUITY, SAFETY, AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

The College's grant-funded initiatives play a central role in advancing health equity. A major example is the $1.5 million health-equity research project led by Dawn Bishop McLin and Don Spann with support from the Robert Wood Johnson Foundation. The project addresses health disparities through research and sustained community engagement, demonstrating how faculty expertise can contribute to broader efforts to improve individual and community well-being.

The Interdisciplinary Alcohol and Drug Studies Center offers another important model of community-based public service. By combining academic knowledge with prevention, education, and public outreach, the Center addresses alcohol misuse, impaired driving, youth safety, and community health throughout Mississippi.

The Center received the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration's Public Service Award in recognition of its work in alcohol prevention and safe driving. Its outreach has reached more than 41,000 students through presentations, educational booths, prevention campaigns, and community programming.

In 2025, the Center secured more than $493,000 to continue its prevention and driver-education initiatives. Director Nita Hilton also received JSU's 2025 Top Grant Award, recognizing her leadership in securing external support and translating that funding into sustained public service.

These achievements demonstrate the value of aligning higher education with community needs. Through research, prevention education, grant development, and public engagement, the College is helping strengthen safety, health, and youth well-being across Mississippi.

Margaret Walker Center archivist, Angela Stewart

THE MARGARET WALKER CENTER

ARCHIVES, MEMORY, & CULTURAL LEGACY

Cultural memory is one of the College of Liberal Arts' most important forms of public work. It is also one of its most delicate. Archives must be preserved. Stories must be interpreted. Public programs must bring history into conversation with the present. Communities must be invited to see themselves in the record.

At Jackson State University, that work is carried forward through the Margaret Walker Center, the COFO Civil Rights Education Center, literary programming, exhibitions, festivals, convocations, and preservation initiatives that connect campus history to regional, national, and global conversations about Black life.

The Margaret Walker Center's materials were featured in the Smithsonian's *At the Vanguard* exhibit, placing JSU-connected archival material in a national museum context. That recognition matters because it shows how the university's collections speak beyond campus. The archive is not simply a repository of documents; it is a source of public knowledge about literature, civil rights, Black women's intellectual history, and the long struggle for cultural memory.

Jackson State University faculty, staff, students, administrators, along with President Gregory, were invited to attend a special preview of "At the Vanguard: Making and Saving History at Historically Black Colleges and Universities."

Director of JSU's Office of Community Engagement Dr. Heather Denne', Muralist and Artist Sabrina Howard, Home Depot representative Charity Burnley, JSU student Zaria Miller, and Director of the Margaret Walker Center and COFO Civil Rights Education Center, Dr. Robert Luckett.

CULTURAL MEMORY LIVES NOT ONLY IN ARCHIVES, BUT ALSO IN THE SPACES, PROGRAMS, AND PARTNERSHIPS THAT KEEP HISTORY ACTIVE.

LIBERAL ARTS IN THE COMMUNITY

PLACE, MEMORY, & COMMUNITY IMPROVEMENT

Rooms matter. Outdoor spaces matter. Signage, gathering areas, archives, murals, and public entrances all shape how people encounter history. For institutions rooted in civil rights memory and Black literary legacy, preservation is not simply about saving materials. It is also about caring for the spaces that hold those materials and welcome the public into them.

In 2025, the COFO Center and Margaret Walker Center benefited from a triple Home Depot Retool Your School grant package totaling $170,000. The package included $80,000 for campus improvement, $40,000 for an innovation lounge, and $50,000 for community improvement tied to the COFO beautification project.

That support strengthened the physical and public-facing presence of historic spaces on campus. The COFO beautification project, in particular, connected community improvement to civil rights memory. It brought together university leaders, community engagement staff, students, artists, and partners in a visible act of care for a site tied to Mississippi's freedom struggle.

INSTITUTIONAL DEVELOPMENT
MAKING THE WORK POSSIBLE

Some of the College's essential work begins well before anyone enters a lecture hall, a performer steps onto the stage, or a researcher embarks on a new project. It all starts with a foundation of support: grants, partnerships, institutional confidence, and the belief that liberal arts contribute meaningfully to public life. External funding has played a significant role in turning the College's ideas into tangible programs, performances, archives, research initiatives, and community partnerships.

A notable example of such support is the Margaret Walker Center's $450,000 grant from the Mellon Foundation. This two-part project is focused on fostering long-term sustainability, enhancing capacity for growth, and amplifying impact. Such funding goes beyond mere operational assistance; it enables cultural institutions to plan, preserve, expand, and solidify their roles as centers of public humanities.

In 2025, the Center received further support with a $317,039 award from the Institute of Museum and Library Services. This funding aided in the relocation, preservation, and digital-access efforts for the archives during renovations, ensuring that the valuable materials remained protected and integrated into a strategic preservation plan.

Additionally, Detrice Roberts from the Department of History and Philosophy received backing from the University of Southern Mississippi's Digital Humanities Hub. This support facilitated collaboration with the Department of Art and Africana Digital Humanities Lab on a project to digitize the African Art Collection. The endeavor resulted in an online database for researchers and provided students with hands-on opportunities to learn about the digitization process, merging technology with tradition in an informative educational experience.

Grant funding makes possible the temporary relocation of the Margaret Walker Center archives.

EXTERNAL SUPPORT HELPS TRANSFORM SCHOLARSHIP, MEMORY, PERFORMANCE, AND PUBLIC SERVICE INTO LASTING INSTITUTIONAL IMPACT.

Research & Staff Excellence

BY THE NUMBERS

$1.5M

HEALTH-EQUITY RESEARCH AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT PROJECT

$509K

NATIONAL SCIENCE FOUNDATION SUPPORT FOR RACIAL-TRAUMA RESEARCH

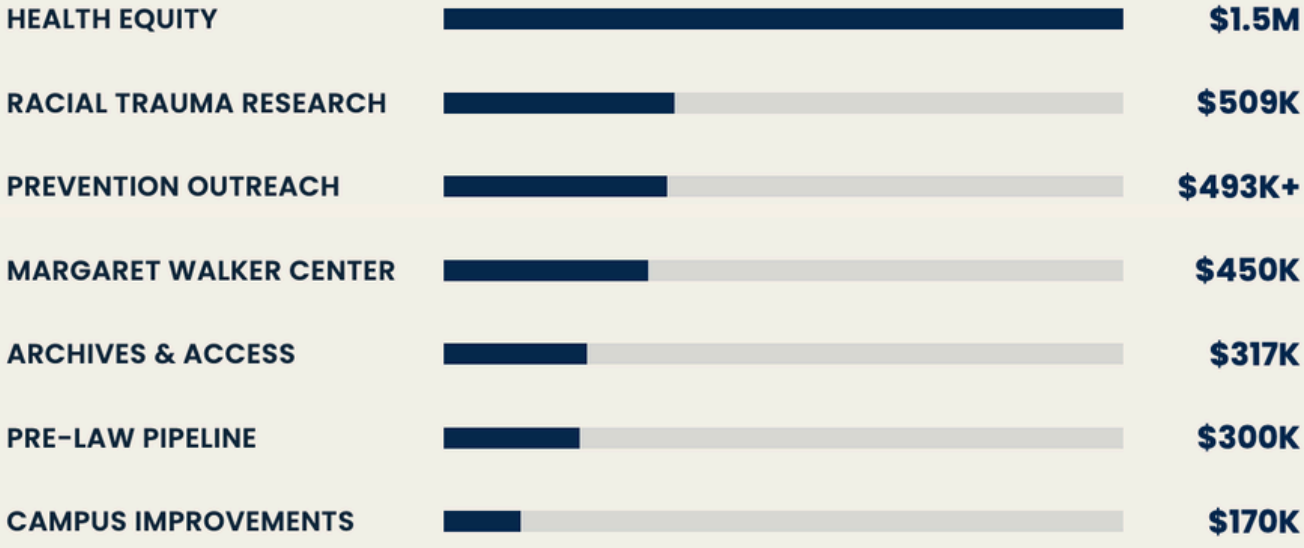
$493K+

SECURED IN 2025 FOR PREVENTION AND DRIVER-EDUCATION INITIATIVES

INVESTING IN IMPACT

Major grants & investments

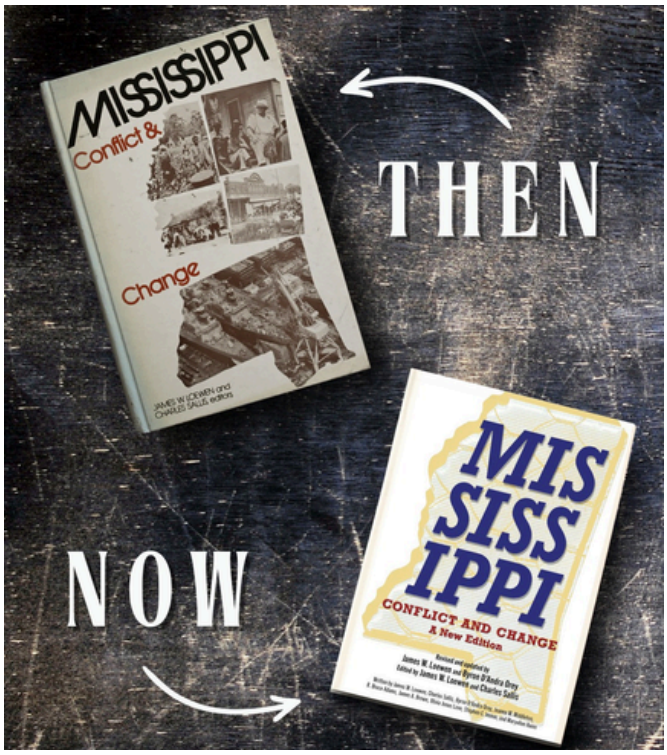
Support for research, student opportunity, cultural preservation and public service.



FACULTY RESEARCH ON PUBLIC LIFE, HISTORY, & SOCIAL CONDITIONS

The School of Social and Behavioral Sciences researches how institutions, histories, and policies shape public life, covering topics like community memory, policy impacts, race and trauma in politics, crisis management, and experiences of grief and well-being. It also looks into how migration, labor, spirituality, and power histories influence the present.

In History and Philosophy, Lomarsh Roopnarine's edited volumes on Indian indenture, migration, nationalism, and post-slavery identity expand on global and diasporic themes. His works include *Historical and Contemporary Aspects of Indian Indenture and Migration*, *Legacy of Slavery and Indentured Labour*, and *Nationalism, Transnationalism and Identity in the Age of Post-Slavery Indenture and Migration*, exploring labor systems and colonial histories across the Caribbean, South Asia, and postcolonial worlds.



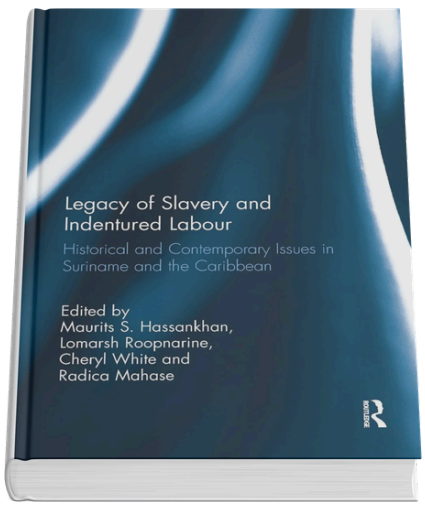
In Political Science, Byron D'Andra Orey's scholarship and professional leadership place JSU faculty at the center of major disciplinary conversations. His work includes a chapter in *Necessary Conversations: Understanding Racism as a Barrier to Achieving Health Equity* and a *Social Science Quarterly* article on racial differences in distress during COVID-19. Political Science faculty have also been connected to National Science Foundation-supported research on racial trauma and political behavior. Orey's election as president of the Southern Political Science Association further reflects JSU's role in shaping the field.

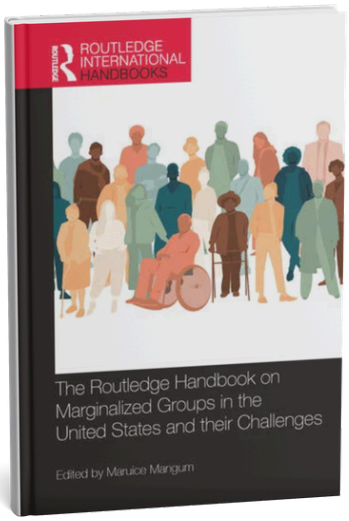
Maurice Mangum's research expands the department's work on political participation, gun violence, marginalized communities, and institutional inequality. His 2026 Routledge volume, *Handbook on Marginalized Groups in the United States and Their Challenges*, brings together scholarship examining the political, social, and structural conditions confronting marginalized populations.

In Public Policy and Administration, Gloria J. Billingsley's scholarship and leadership address voting rights, social policy, public-affairs education, and accreditation standards. Her encyclopedia chapter on the Fourteenth Amendment, voting rights, and social policy connects constitutional history to contemporary public administration and civic life. Her appointment as chair of NASPAA's Commission on Peer Review and Accreditation also demonstrates how faculty research and professional service help shape national standards in public-affairs education.

Jae-Young Ko's scholarship adds an important policy and infrastructure dimension. His publications in *BioPhysical Economics and Sustainability*, the *Journal of Jeju Studies*, and the *Online Journal of Rural and Urban Research* include research on the Jackson water crisis. This work connects public-policy scholarship to environmental systems, infrastructure, municipal governance, and the lived experiences of communities navigating prolonged crisis.
In Criminal Justice and Sociology, faculty research addresses violence, public safety, institutional failure, disaster, and community-based prevention. Xiaoli Su presented "Mobilizing Churches in Community-Based Violence Prevention: Jackson, MS, as a Typical Case," highlighting the role of community institutions in addressing violence and social harm. Vineeth Vijayan's dissertation, *School Shootings in the United States: An Analysis of Micro and Macro Level Variables*, contributes to research on school violence, public safety, and the social conditions that shape risk and prevention.

Thomas M. Kersen's recent coauthored scholarship examines the cumulative consequences of environmental crisis and infrastructure failure in Jackson. "A Legacy of Recreancy?: Perceptions of Routinized Governmental Failure in Jackson, MS," published in the *International Journal of Disaster Risk Reduction* in 2025, considers how repeated institutional failures shape public perception and trust. A follow-up study, "Resource Loss, Slow Violence, and Psychosocial Stress: The 2022 Pearl River Flood in Jackson, Mississippi," published in *Social Sciences* in 2026, examines the material and psychological consequences of flooding and prolonged infrastructural instability. Together, the studies connect disaster research to resource loss, slow violence, governmental responsibility, and psychosocial stress.





These projects establish the School of Social and Behavioral Sciences as a center for research on public life. Faculty examine the structures that shape communities and the experiences that define human behavior, civic responsibility, justice, policy, memory, and social change.

THEE AFRICANA DIGITAL HUMANITIES *LAB*

The Africana Digital Humanities Lab is establishing a collaborative infrastructure for research, teaching, and public engagement at the intersections of Black history, archival practice, digital technology, cultural preservation, and storytelling.

African American art history forms a major area of the Lab's work. Grant-funded development of AfricanAmericanArtHistory.com is expanding a public platform for research by HBCU students and faculty on African American artists, exhibitions, and visual culture. In collaboration with the Department of Art and with support from Title III funding, the Lab also helped produce K–12 lesson plans centered on African American artists and developed an online platform through which educators can access and use these resources.

Additional work in digital access is being advanced through a grant awarded to Detrice Roberts by the Mississippi Digital Humanities Hub at the University of Southern Mississippi. The project supports the digitization and public interpretation of African art in Jackson State University's collection, engaging students in object research, metadata development, digital imaging, and collections-based scholarship.

A central focus of the Lab's community-engaged work is its partnership with Scott Ford Houses, Inc. through Monument Lab's Mellon-supported Re:Generation program. The project combines historic preservation, archival research, oral history, museum interpretation, and public programming. In conducting research for the project, the Lab also developed an archival database for the Smith Robertson Museum and Cultural Center, digitizing and organizing photographs, family records, birth certificates, midwife permits, museum objects, and oral histories. Students from the History Club and Department of Art contributed to the research, documentation, and interpretation.

The Lab also provides direct support for faculty and graduate research. In summer 2026, it supported a faculty research project led by Rondee Gaines, expanding its role as a platform for interdisciplinary scholarship and experimentation. In Fall 2026, it welcomed research fellow Dr. Denae Powell and a new cohort of student fellows. The Lab will continue to support student and faculty fellows who will contribute to archival, digital, and community-engaged projects while developing their own research and professional skills.

The African Art Collection has been fully digitized with metadata records available via a custom-built art collections database.

Ashanti Stiff, Brian Hunter, and Makaylen Bingham-Babino presented on their Digital Humanities projects at the Africana Digital Humanities @ HBCUs Convening at Clark Atlanta University.

BUILDING WHAT COMES NEXT

Improvement of Campus Culture and Enhancement of JSU Brand

The College of Liberal Arts is building its future through programs, partnerships, and professional pathways that extend learning beyond the classroom. Across disciplines, faculty and staff are creating structures through which students can move from academic study into graduate education, creative practice, public service, civic leadership, and sustained engagement with the communities around them.

In the Department of Music, the introduction of an online Master of Music Education degree, revisions to undergraduate and graduate curricula, and the revival of the Orff-Schulwerk certificate program have expanded access for current and aspiring educators. These developments strengthen academic infrastructure while responding to the changing needs of students and working professionals.

The Bob Owens Pre-Law Center, under the direction of Dr. Charles Irvin, is also growing. Through law-school visits, LSAT preparation, mentoring, judicial symposia, professional-development programs, and partnerships with legal practitioners, the Center is creating a clearer route from undergraduate study to law school and public service. Students gain access to the professional knowledge, institutional networks, and preparation needed to imagine themselves as attorneys, advocates, and civic leaders.

Public engagement is expanding through partnerships that connect the College to audiences beyond campus. Collaborations involving English and Modern Languages, Speech Communication, the Mississippi Book Festival, Lemuria Books, and Visit Jackson culminated in a sold-out event featuring Tabitha Brown. The gathering demonstrated how literary culture and public programming can bring university scholarship, creative practice, and community life into conversation.

In Public Policy and Administration, student preparation is visible in measurable outcomes. From Summer 2023 through Spring 2025, the department recorded 29 internship placements, giving students experience in professional settings where policy, administration, and public service intersect.

These developments show a College building with intention. New degrees, professional centers, internships, public programs, and community partnerships are creating durable pathways through which students can test their knowledge, develop professional identities, and begin contributing to the fields and communities they will serve.

Ramon Jackson leads an Orff-Schulwerk workshop at Jackson State University.

The annual Creative Arts and Scholarly Engagement Festival connects student creative work with public programming and nationally recognized literary scholarship.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This report reflects the collective work of the students, faculty, staff, alumni, departments, centers, and affiliated units of Jackson State University's College of Liberal Arts. The achievements represented in these pages were made possible through their scholarship, teaching, creative practice, mentorship, leadership, service, and sustained commitment to the College's public mission.

The College gratefully acknowledges the cultural institutions, schools, professional organizations, foundations, government agencies, community groups, and university partners that have supported student learning, faculty research, artistic production, archival preservation, public programming, and institutional development.

We also thank the photographers, writers, researchers, designers, and contributors whose work made it possible to document and share the College's progress.

Images courtesy of Jackson State University departments, centers, archives, and community partners.
Report developed by Thee Africana Digital Humanities Lab.

Ayer Hall, 1903 and 2025

COLLEGE OF LIBERAL ARTS, JACKSON STATE UNIVERSITY
FALL 2023-SPRING 2026

COLLEGE OF LIBERAL ARTS *IMPACT REPORT*

SCHOLARSHIP. CREATIVITY.
LEADERSHIP. PUBLIC PURPOSE.

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